

Exclusive club: Zverev became the first German to make the Wimbledon final since Boris Becker in 1995 and the 13th man in the Open Era to reach all four Grand Slam finals. AFP

puzzle of how to return Zverev's second serve. Sinner retreated from 7.5 feet behind the baseline in the first set, to 12 feet in the second, to a whopping 15 feet in the third. There, Sinner had more time to loop serve returns deep and neutralise Zverev's accurate, high-bouncing serves.

Zverev lost the plot in the fourth set, again ignoring Nadal's advice and becoming passive. Meanwhile, Sinner became even more aggressive to secure the only service break he would need for a 4-3 lead. When the relentless Italian crushed a timid Zverev forehand with a forehand winner, his team rose in unison, like puppets on strings, and pumped their right fists in celebration.

Two games later, Sinner (**below**) wrapped up his convincing 6-7(7), 7-6(2), 6-3, 6-4 title defence with a forehand winner into the open court.

McEnroe praised the valiant but ultimately outclassed runner-up, saying, "This is a huge step up for

Zverev. Remember, he never got past the fourth round before. Sinner lifted his game when he had to. We love Zverev. But Carlos Alcaraz, get back here."

The pro tour dearly missed the charismatic seven-time Major champion and former No. 1, who has been sidelined with a wrist injury since April. It was uncertain whether Alcaraz, who recently withdrew from the upcoming Canadian Open in Toronto, would return in time to defend his US Open title.

Ironically, Sinner looked vulnerable only in his first match against Miomir Kecmanovic, a husky Serbian with an 11-16 match record who had dropped down to the Challenger circuit to regain his confidence. Sinner, rusty after bypassing the grass-court tune-up events, came back for a 4-6, 6-3, 6-7(6), 6-2, 6-3 victory.

Sinner fully regained his A-game for his semifinal showdown with Novak Djokovic. The GOAT upset Sinner in a five-set thriller in the Australian Open semifinals in January when the Serb saved 16 of 18 break points. This time, though, the 39-year-old Djokovic looked more ageing than ageless. He played more defensive than ever and meekly went down 6-4, 6-4, 6-4.

Always gracious in defeat, Djokovic lavishly praised the versatile offence of the young superstar.

"Attack his first serve? You cannot," the Serbian explained. "You can try to read it, chip it, block it, get it back in play. Very unpredictable serve, great variety, great balance, great pop. He's using his height extremely well. Also, the second serve is very deep in the box. A lot of rotation. He can go for speed. He's just super solid. He backs it up with the first aggressive shot. If you play a shorter return, you're again, on your back foot. It's really, really tough to play him, particularly when he serves."

The fact that Djokovic, a part-time player this year competing in only his fifth tournament, made the semifinals was a remarkable testament to his elite longevity. Incredibly, since 2003, there has been at least one member of the Big Three in every Wimbledon semifinal.

But the Herculean effort required to outlast No. 3 Felix Auger-Aliassime 7-6(10), 3-6, 6-3, 6-7(4), 7-6(4) in their 5-hour, 15-minute quarterfinal likely cost Djokovic any chance of upsetting Sinner, even with two days of rest.

With spectators chanting "Nole! Nole!", their sentimental favourite channelled memories of his 10-2 record in five-set Wimbledon matches. Djokovic dominated the match tie-break, highlighted by an enthralling 21-shot power rally that he won for an insurmountable 9-4 lead.



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